

Session 19: Israel's Shepherd

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors develop shepherding as a metaphor for leadership throughout the biblical story.
- Israel's kings are condemned as bad shepherds who feed on the flock.
- Yahweh declares he will shepherd the people himself, but he also announces that his servant David will shepherd them too, further expanding the portrait of messianic hope.

Ezekiel 34-48: Israel's Restoration in the Messianic Kingdom

"If Israel's rebellion had meant the destruction of all the great realities through which their relationship with God was expressed and embodied, then the restoration of Israel must involve the restoration of those same realities in a new world order that Yahweh would bring about after the purging of Israel in exile. The chapters that follow outline God's work of restoration at every level of his relationship with Israel."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [*The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit*](#). IVP Academic. 228.

Ezekiel's vision of the restoration is "a future which is dependent not upon man's ability to respond but upon God's willingness to act. The possibility of a response from Israel—however improbable—is not wholly excluded. But at the same time it is expressed in such a way that the response is really no matter of human endeavor but entirely of divine grace. For the stress laid in these passages is the will of God that men should live rather than that they should die."

Ackroyd, Peter R. (1968). [*Exile and Restoration*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 228.

The themes of these chapters pick up the many hints of future restoration Ezekiel has made earlier in the book ([Ezek. 6:8-10](#), [11:17-20](#), [16:53-63](#), [17:22-24](#), [20:39-44](#), [28:24-26](#)). They also follow the logic of the great covenant statement in [Leviticus 26:40-45](#), which held out hope that after bearing the curses of covenant violation, Israel could always repent and turn back to Yahweh, who would renew the covenant (see also [Deut. 4:25-31](#), [30:1-10](#)).

The compositional structure of Ezekiel's oracles of hope shows a systematic restoration of all that was lost in the exile.

1. Restoration of Yahweh as Israel's kingship through the messianic shepherd-king (34)
2. Restoration of Yahweh's land as a place for Israel (35:1-36:15)
3. Restoration of Yahweh's honor (36:16-38)
4. Restoration of Yahweh's covenant people (37)
5. Restoration of Yahweh's rule over all nations (38-39)
6. Restoration of Yahweh's presence among his people (40-46)

Literary Design of Ezekiel 34-37

Ezekiel 34:1-31			Ezekiel 35:1-36:15		Ezekiel 36:16-37:28		
34:1-16	34:17-22	34:23-31	35:1-15	36:1-15	36:16-38	37:1-14	37:15-28
• Shepherds of Israel • Mts. of Israel		• New shepherd • David the chief • New covenant of peace • Multiplying human flock	• Oracle against Mt. Seir/Edom • Desolation & ruin	• Oracle for the Mts. of Israel • Restoration & vindication • Multiplying humans	• New heart & Spirit to follow commands regather/return re-purified • My human flock	• Spirit brings life to dead bones of Israel	• Two become one to follow commands regather/return re-purified • My human flock • New covenant of peace • New shepherd David

Ezekiel 34-37. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 34

- ¹ And the word of Yahweh came to me saying,
- ² "Son of man, prophesy against **the shepherds of Israel!**
Prophesy and say to them, to **the shepherds**,
'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
Woe, **shepherds of Israel** who have been **shepherding/feeding** themselves!
Should not **the shepherds feed the flock** ?
- ³ You **feed on** the fat,
and you clothe yourselves with the wool,
you slaughter the fat sheep
you don't **feed the flock** .
- ⁴ **Those who are sick you have not strengthened,**
and the diseased you have not healed,
and the broken you have not bound up,
and the scattered you have not brought back,
and the lost you have not searched for,
but with force and with severity you have ruled them.
- ⁵ And so they were **scattered** for lack of a **shepherd**,
and **they became food** for every beast of the field
and they were **scattered** .
- ⁶ **My flock** went astray on all the mountains and on every high hill;
and **my flock** was **scattered** over all the face of the land,
and there was **no one to search or seek** for them."

- ⁷ Therefore, you shepherds, hear the word of Yahweh:
- ⁸ "As I live," declares Yahweh Elohim,
"surely because **my flock has become plunder**,

and **my flock** **has become** **food** for all the beasts of the field for lack of a **shepherd**,
and my **shepherds did not search** for **my flock** ,
but rather the **shepherds fed** themselves
and they did not **feed** **my flock** .

⁹ Therefore, you **shepherds**, hear the word of Yahweh:

¹⁰ 'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
Behold, I am against the **shepherds**,
and I will seek **my flock** from their hand,
and I will make them stop from **feeding** **the flock** ,
and the shepherds will not **feed** themselves anymore,
and I will deliver **my flock** from their mouth,
so that **they will not be** **food** for them."

¹¹ For thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Look, **I myself will search** for **my flock** and seek them out,
¹² like a **shepherd seeks** for his herd,
on a day when he is among his flock who are spread out,
and I will seek for **my flock** ,
and **I will deliver them** from all the places to which they were **scattered**
on a day of clouds and gloomy darkness,
¹³ and I will bring them out from the peoples
and I will gather them from the lands,
and bring them to their own land;
and I will **feed** them on **the mountains of Israel** ,
by the streams, and in all the inhabited places of the land.
¹⁴ I will **feed** them in a good **feeding-pastures**,
and their grazing ground will be on **the mountains of Israel** .
There they will lie down on good grazing ground,
and they will feed in rich **feeding-pasture** on **the mountains of Israel** .

¹⁵ I will **feed** **my flock** ,
and I will have them lie down,"
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁶ "**The lost I will seek,**
the scattered I will return back,
the broken I will bind up,
the sick I will strengthen,
but the fat and the strong I will destroy.
I will **feed** them with **judgment** .

¹⁷ As for you, **my flock** ,"
thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Look, **I will judge** **between one sheep and another sheep**,
between the rams and the male goats.

18 Is it a small thing for you that you should **feed** in **the good feeding-pasture**,
and that **you tread down with your feet** the rest of your **feeding pastures**,
and that **you drink** of the clear waters,
and that **you must muddy the rest with your feet** ?
19 and that **my flock** must **feed** on what **you tread down with your feet** ,
and that **they must drink** what **you muddy with your feet** ?!"

20 Therefore, thus says Yahweh Elohim to them,
"Look, I, even **I, will judge** **between the fat sheep and the lean sheep**.
21 Because with your side and with shoulder you push others aside,
and you thrust at all the weak with your horns,
until you have scattered them abroad,
22 so **I will deliver my flock** ,
and they will no longer be plunder,
and **I will judge** **between one sheep and another sheep**.

23 **And I will establish over them** one **shepherd**,
and he will **feed** them,
namely, **my servant David** ,
he will **feed** them himself,
and he will be their **shepherd**,
24 **and I, Yahweh, will be their Elohim** ,
and **my servant David** will be chief among them.
I Yahweh have spoken.

25 **I will make a covenant of peace** with them,
and I will stop **harmful animals from the land** ,
so they may live securely in the wilderness,
and so they can sleep in the woods.
26 and I will give them and all around my hill a **blessing** ,
and I will cause **rain** to come down in its season,
and they will be **rains** of **blessing** .
27 and the tree of the field will give its fruit,
and the land will give its increase,
and they will be secure on their land.

And they will know that I am Yahweh,
when I break the bars of their yoke,
and **when I deliver them** from the hand of those who enslaved them.
28 and they will **no longer be a plunder** **for the nations** ,
and **the animals of the land** will not **eat** them,

but they will live securely,
and no one will make them afraid.

29 **I will establish for them** a place of planting for a name,
and they will not again be victims of famine in the land,
and they will **not carry the reproach of the nations** anymore,
30 and they will know that **I, Yahweh their Elohim**, am with them,
and that they, the house of Israel, are my people,”
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.
31 “And as for you, my flock,
the flock of my pasture,
you are humans,
and I am your Elohim,”
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

Ezekiel 34:1-31. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Judgment on Israel’s Shepherds

Ezekiel addresses Israel’s shepherd-leaders in [34:1-16](#). Shepherd is a key royal metaphor used of Israel’s rulers ([2 Sam. 5:2](#), [7:7](#)) and of Yahweh as king ([Hos. 4:16](#); [Mic. 7:14](#)). Ezekiel seems to have picked up Jeremiah’s similar accusation ([Jer. 23:1-6](#)) and developed it. Israel’s kings have failed and abused their position (see their portrayal in 1-2 Kgs.), so Yahweh will remove them and personally come to restore and rule his people.

Judgement Between the Sheep and the Goats

In [Ezekiel 34:17-22](#), Israel’s leaders have become resistant to the purposes of their God, and so they have become God’s enemy. The imagery of feeding and drinking and robbing from the poor fits with the more detailed social critique of Israel’s leaders found in the other prophets like [Amos 5-6](#) or [Micah 3-5](#).

Notice how this scene became a foundational metaphor for Jesus in his critique of Israel’s leaders who rejected his disciples and their message of the Kingdom of God ([Matt. 25:31-46](#)).

Israel’s Bad Goats and the New Shepherd

Ezekiel extends the shepherd metaphor throughout the next section ([Ezek. 34:23-31](#)).

The messianic king is set over the people in 34:23-24. He is “one shepherd” (see the reunion of the covenant people in [37:15-28](#)), “my servant” (see [Isa. 40-55](#)), “a ruler/prince” (Heb. *nasi*). The word “king” (Heb. *melek*) is mostly avoided in Ezekiel to distinguish this messianic figure from the recent sons of David who utterly failed.

Expanding the theme in 34:25-29, Ezekiel recalls the covenantal blessings from [Leviticus 26:3-13](#) and [Deuteronomy 28:1-14](#). Ezekiel quotes the classic covenantal formula (34:24, 30) and sees a renewal of the covenant.

Notice the interplay of Yahweh's personal action and that of the messianic king in this chapter. Yahweh will "tend as shepherd" (34:14) and be a "shepherd in the midst of his flock" (34:12). Messiah will "tend as shepherd" (34:23) and be a "ruler in the midst of them" (34:24).

The vocabulary used of Yahweh's shepherding activity seems to have influenced Jesus' view of his own mission. Yahweh "saves" and "gathers" the scattered sheep (34:13), "leads them to good pasture" (34:14), "causes them to lie down" (34:15), and "seeks the lost, restores the scattered, binds up the broken, strengthens the weak" (34:16). Compare this to Matthew 9:36, 10:6, 25:31-33; Luke 15:3-7, 19:9; and John 10.

Tale of Two Mountains: Judgment on Mount Seir, Salvation for Mountains of Israel

Ezekiel 35:1-36:15 has been edited together as a single literary unit consisting of two contrasting panels (35:1 governs the whole section and parallels 36:1). Both panels focus on the desolation of the mountains of Israel, the resulting public shame, and their restoration due to Yahweh's mercy.

Oracle Against Mount Seir (Ezek. 35:1-15)

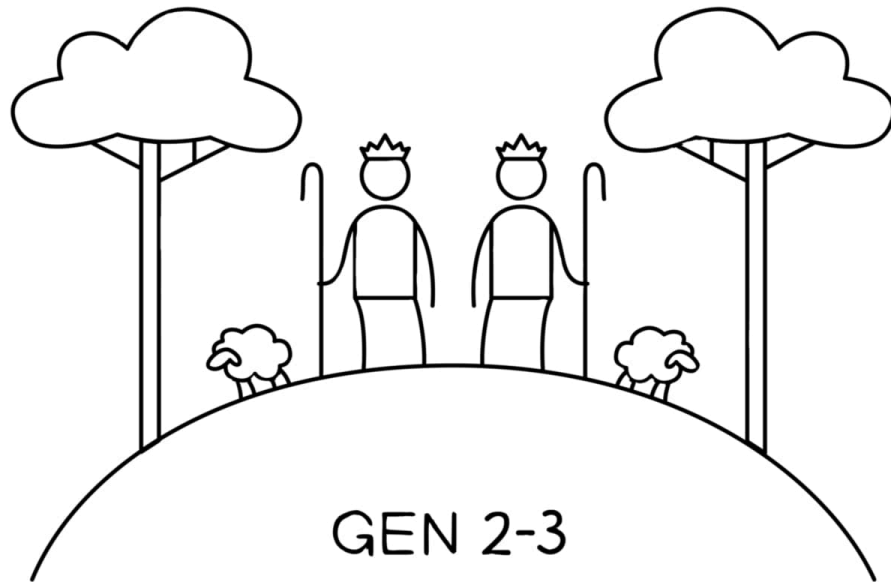
The Edomites (who inhabited the mountains of Seir) took advantage of the vacuum created by the Babylonian exile by quickly plundering the remains of Israel (35:10, 36:2; Obad. 1:8-14; Ps. 137:7). Therefore, the mountains of Edom will suffer the same fate as the mountains of Israel under the covenant curses (35:3-4 echo 6:14).

Oracle to the Mountains of Israel (Ezek. 36:1-15)

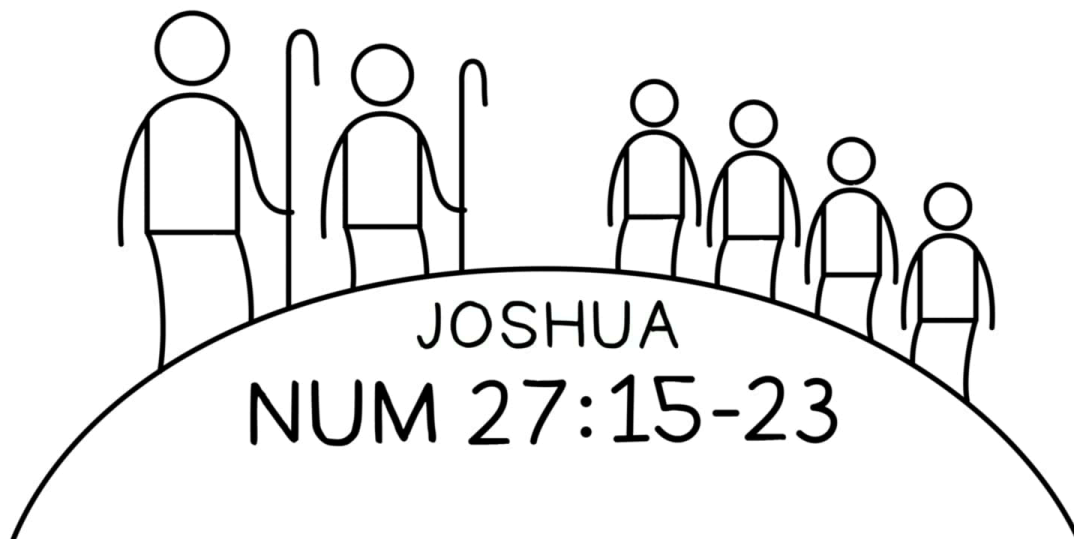
In a reversal of chapter 6, Ezekiel announces restoration for the mountains of Israel as a sign to the rest of the world. There is likely a wordplay at work in 36:5 in which Edom is linked with all nations (the Hebrew consonants of Edom are the same as the word "humanity," אדם).

The vocabulary of this restoration is all drawn from the covenant blessings of Leviticus 26:3-10, but this begs the question, How will Israel change and become obedient to the covenant to experience its blessings, given their pattern of failure? The next section answers this question.

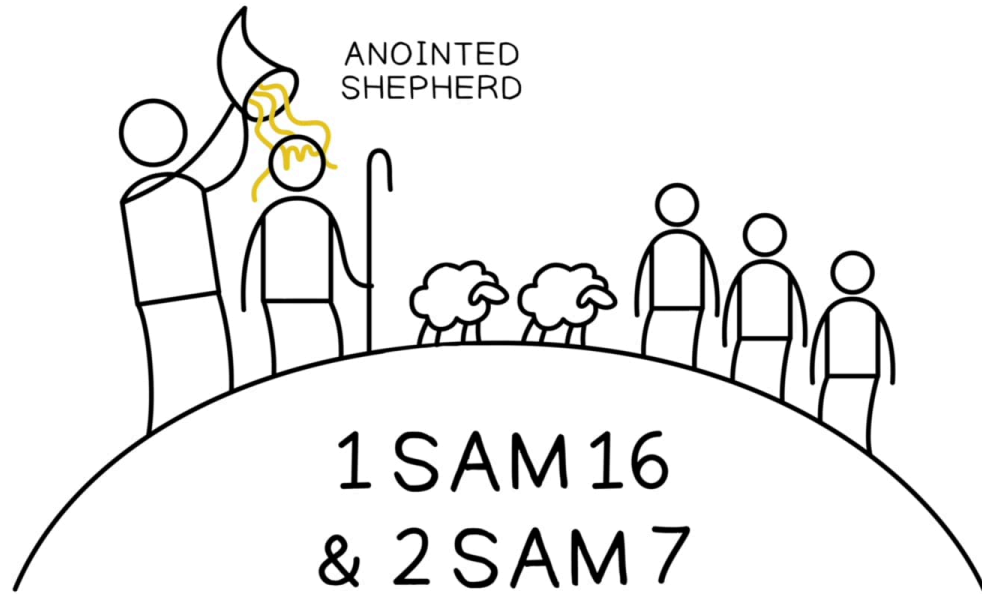
Shepherds Caring for God's People



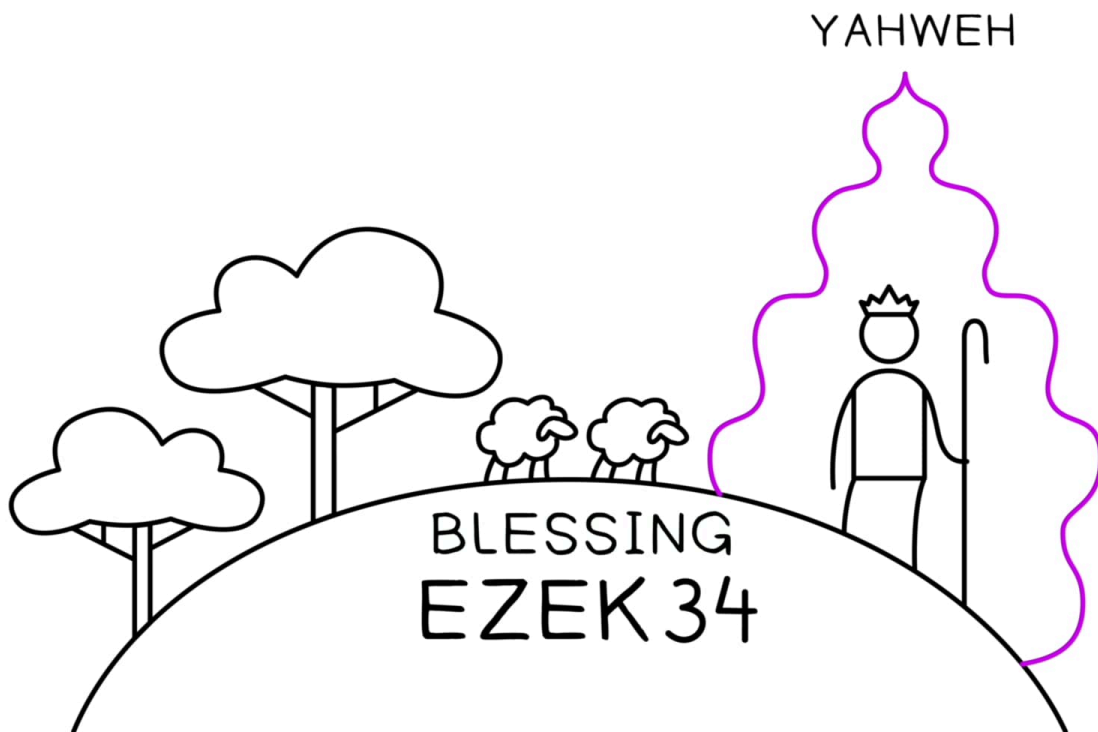
Shepherds Caring for God's People 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



Shepherds Caring for God's People 2. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



Shepherds Caring for God's People 3. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



Shepherds Caring for God's People 4. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

What significance do you find in the interplay between God's action and human partnership when God says both "I will" shepherd the flock and "my servant David ... will tend them" (Ezek. 34:11-24)?